

A RIGHT SIDE UP STUDIO BIBLE STUDY

LIVING HOPE

Meeting the Risen Jesus

JOHN 20-21



Four encounters with the risen Christ, for personal reflection or group study — with Scripture, teaching, and space to respond.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Guide

This guide moves through four movements — the World, the Garden, the Room, and the Shore — each pairing a short teaching with the full text of Scripture and space to respond. There is no correct pace. Read slowly. Sit with the text longer than feels necessary. Answer honestly; there are no wrong answers here. Move through it in a single sitting, one movement a day across Holy Week, or together with a group — a few questions at a time, read aloud, followed by open conversation.

Read • Sit with the Text • Reflect • Use However It Fits

We cannot stop telling resurrection stories.

Every generation tells them in a hundred different forms. Buried in the human imagination—in every culture and every century—is a haunting intuition: death cannot be the end. The darkest moment cannot be the final one.

We keep returning to stories in which what looked finished begins again, what was lost is restored, and love proves stronger than the grave. We keep telling resurrection stories because we were made for one.

And the one we were made for is not a myth, or a metaphor, or a movie. It is a moment. A real moment, in a real garden, in a real year of history.

But the resurrection of Jesus is not an escape from the real world. It arrives inside one: political chaos, economic pressure, disputed truth, private grief, wounded belief, and remembered failure.

| *The world did not become stable before Jesus rose. He rose in the middle of it.*

And then Jesus meets people there—not as abstractions, but by name, by touch, and beside a small fire. These are not three arguments for hope. They are three encounters with the living Christ.

ORIENTATION

The World. The Garden. The Room. The Shore.

Four places. Four encounters.

THE WORLD

Where an empire was unraveling, and something was quietly being put back together.

THE GARDEN

Where grief met a gardener who knew her name.

THE ROOM

Where doubt met wounds that were still open.

THE SHORE

Where failure met a fire, a question, and a calling that had not changed.

This is where the resurrection still meets us.

01

THE WORLD

What if resurrection isn't an escape from the world's chaos, but Jesus meeting you inside it?

SETTING THE SCENE • LUKE 3:1-2

In 31 AD, a political assassination shook the Roman Empire.

Tiberius Caesar had grown disillusioned with power but kept its privileges, retreating to the island of Capri and handing the daily rule of the empire to a man named Sejanus. For years Sejanus consolidated influence and collected the loyalty of the elite—until Tiberius decided he had collected too much.

Sejanus arrived at the Senate expecting to be named co-emperor. Instead, charges were read aloud before the entire chamber. He was executed before the day was out.

Was he guilty? Was Tiberius the real danger? Historians still argue. The people living through it had no way to know what was actually true. The official story and the real story were not always the same thing.

The fallout was immediate. The political class fractured. Riots broke out. Purges followed. Nobody was sure who to trust.

Then, in 33 AD—the very year of Jesus' death and resurrection—an old lending law, ignored for years, was suddenly enforced. Debts were called in. Accounts differ on how severe it was, but one thing is certain: ordinary people paid for it. Land lost. Freedom lost. While the powerful debated the scope of the damage, real families absorbed it.

Underneath all of it, tension was building in the provinces—the conquered territories at the edges of the empire, historically restless, now more combustible than ever.

None more so than Judea. Occupied. Volatile. A population that had waited generations for liberation, governed by a man named Pontius Pilate who knew that the wrong arrest, the wrong execution, could ignite the whole region. This is the world Pilate was navigating two days before our story begins.

In a Garden, Not a Palace

This is not an ancient history lesson. It is an introduction to the neighborhood.

Political chaos. Economic wreckage. A culture that cannot agree on what is true. A world coming apart at the seams—while everyone can feel the pressure building,

and no one knows when or how it will break. That is the world the resurrection is born into. Not so different from ours.

And here is what is worth seeing: while that world was unraveling, something was quietly being put back together. Not in a palace. Not in the Senate. Not in any of the rooms where the chaos was being managed and mismanaged.

The world did not become stable before Jesus rose. He rose in the middle of it.

And the first person to encounter it was not a general, a senator, or an emperor. It was a woman named Mary—showing up in the dark, heartbroken, to finish a funeral. She had no idea she was about to walk into the most important moment in human history.

SCRIPTURE • LUKE 3:1-2 (NIV)

¹ In the fifteenth year of the reign of Tiberius Caesar—when Pontius Pilate was governor of Judea, Herod tetrarch of Galilee, his brother Philip tetrarch of Iturea and Traconitis, and Lysanias tetrarch of Abilene— ² during the high-priesthood of Annas and Caiaphas, the word of God came to John son of Zechariah in the wilderness.

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REFLECT

Where do you see today's instability echo Rome's—in politics, the economy, or what is even considered true anymore? Name it. Then ask what it might mean that God has already proven he moves in exactly this kind of world.

PRAYER

God who moved while empires argued—move in my chaos too. I do not need a stable world to trust you in. You have never needed one either.

02

THE GARDEN

*Can you hear your name spoken before the
grief has finished with you?*

MARY MAGDALENE • JOHN 20:1-18

It starts as a funeral.

Early on the first day of the week, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb. The Easter story does not start as a triumph. It begins in grief.

She cannot wait for sunrise. Grief does not wait. The Sabbath came fast after Jesus died—no time for the spices, the oils, or the full mourning rites. Mary comes back the first moment she possibly can. She has come to finish a funeral.

This loss is larger than losing someone she loved. Jesus had delivered her from a darkness no human hands could reach. She had reordered her entire life around the conviction that God's future had arrived in him. His death is the loss of hope on a crushing scale.

The stone is already moved.

Mary does not assume resurrection. Her mind goes to the next worst possibility: someone has taken the body. She runs for Peter and John. They look inside, find the linen cloths, and leave bewildered.

Mary stays. She is left outside the tomb with the questions they cannot answer and the grief they cannot carry for her.

The story begins again in a garden.

The Bible begins with a garden, where God breathes life into dust and rests on the seventh day. Now, on the first day of a new week, in another garden, creation begins again. Mary is standing at the hinge of history, but she cannot see it yet.

Then he speaks her name.

She turns and sees a man she takes for the gardener. "Woman, why are you crying? Who is it you are looking for?" She asks him where the body has been taken.

| *Jesus said to her, "Mary."*

Our name is the sweetest sound to our own ears. She can see Jesus and not recognize him until he speaks hers. Hope is not wishful thinking here. Hope has flesh and blood and is standing in front of her.

Jesus does not shame Mary for failing to understand. He meets her inside the grief and turns her toward a future she could not have imagined. Then he gives her something to do: go, and tell them.

As early as the third century, the church called Mary the “Apostle to the Apostles”—the one sent to announce the resurrection to those who would carry the news into the world. A woman once discarded becomes the first witness and the first messenger.

SCRIPTURE • JOHN 20:1-18 (NIV)

¹ Early on the first day of the week, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb and saw that the stone had been removed from the entrance. ² So she came running to Simon Peter and the other disciple, the one Jesus loved, and said, “They have taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we don’t know where they have put him!” ³ So Peter and the other disciple started for the tomb. ⁴ Both were running, but the other disciple outran Peter and reached the tomb first. ⁵ He bent over and looked in at the strips of linen lying there but did not go in. ⁶ Then Simon Peter came along behind him and went straight into the tomb. He saw the strips of linen lying there, ⁷ as well as the cloth that had been wrapped around Jesus’ head. The cloth was still lying in its place, separate from the linen. ⁸ Finally the other disciple, who had reached the tomb first, also went inside. He saw and believed. ⁹ (They still did not understand from Scripture that Jesus had to rise from the dead.) ¹⁰ Then the disciples went back to where they were staying. ¹¹ Now Mary stood outside the tomb crying. As she wept, she bent over to look into the tomb ¹² and saw two angels in white, seated where Jesus’ body had been, one at the head and the other at the foot. ¹³ They asked her, “Woman, why are you crying?” “They have taken my Lord away,” she said, “and I don’t know where they have put him.” ¹⁴ At this, she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but she did not realize that it was Jesus. ¹⁵ He asked her, “Woman, why are you crying? Who is it you are looking for?” Thinking he was the gardener, she said, “Sir, if you have carried him away, tell me where you have put him, and I will get him.” ¹⁶ Jesus said to her, “Mary.” She turned toward him and cried out in Aramaic, “Rabboni!” (which means “Teacher”). ¹⁷ Jesus said, “Do not hold on to me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father. Go instead to my brothers and tell them, ‘I am ascending to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God.’” ¹⁸ Mary Magdalene went to the disciples with the news: “I have seen the Lord!” And she told them that he had said these things to her.

REFLECT

Where are you grieving? What promise of Jesus has the grief made you forget? You do not have to stop grieving before you can hear your name spoken.

PRAYER

Meet me in the dark, the way you met Mary. Speak my name before I have the strength to look for you.

03

THE ROOM

*What does Jesus offer a faith that needs to
touch the wounds first?*

THOMAS • JOHN 20:19-29

Locked doors.

That evening, the disciples were together with the doors locked, afraid. Jesus came and stood among them. “Peace be with you.”

He was not trying to be strange or paranormal, and the Gospel writer is not trying to make it more believable than it was. People do not walk through locked doors. If you witnessed something like this and wanted your account taken seriously, you would not invent it—you would only write down what happened, because you would not dare embellish something with the kind of power to bypass space and time. That could only be one person: the one who made them.

Jesus does this twice—because this story is a setup for someone who was not in the room.

Thomas, one of the Twelve, missed it. When the others told him, “We have seen the Lord,” he said, “Unless I see the nail marks in his hands and put my hand into his side, I will not believe.”

This is where the phrase “a doubting Thomas” comes from. He gets a bad reputation for it. But there is something deeper going on than skepticism.

Wounds.

Thomas was not short on evidence. He had watched Jesus feed a crowd with a boy’s lunch. He had seen dead men walk out of tombs, leprosy healed, the paralyzed stand. He had bet his entire life on who Jesus said he was—it was Thomas who once said, “Let us go to Jerusalem, so that we may also die with him.”

But there was one thing that was not supposed to happen. The Messiah was not supposed to die. Thomas—like the others—had quietly still been hoping for a warrior-king, an army, an end to Rome’s occupation. Jesus told them again and again it would not go that way. They did not want to hear it.

So when the pressure came, everything Thomas had staked his life on seemed to be sealed in a tomb. And while everyone around him kept saying Jesus was alive, Thomas had somehow missed every single encounter. Everyone else got a visit. Not him.

His doubt was not really about evidence. It was disappointment. Hurt. A heart that had gone numb to protect itself.

A week later, the disciples were together again, and Thomas was with them. He had not walked away—even without believing, he stayed close to the ones who did. Maybe some part of him was still holding on.

Maybe some part of you is too. Life did not go the way you were promised. You did what you were supposed to do, and it did not work out the way you hoped. Everyone around you seems to have an experience you cannot access.

Though the doors were locked, Jesus came and stood among them. “Peace be with you.” Not, “You should have believed sooner.” Just: peace.

Then he said to Thomas, “Put your finger here; see my hands. Reach out your hand and put it into my side. Stop doubting and believe.”

| *Thomas said to him, “My Lord and my God!”*

Jesus told him, “Because you have seen me, you have believed; blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.”

The emphasis is on the wounds. Thomas’ wounds were unseen. Jesus’ were right there—and became the doorway to Thomas’ healing.

This is what the resurrection means for us: what is true of Jesus will one day be true of us, and of everything broken. The early church called this “firstfruits”—the first sign of a harvest still to come.

Because Jesus knows our doubts rarely need better arguments. They need a body that has been through death and come out the other side, with the power to heal even the hurts we have hidden from everyone, including ourselves.

SCRIPTURE • JOHN 20:19-29 (NIV)

¹⁹ On the evening of that first day of the week, when the disciples were together, with the doors locked for fear of the Jewish leaders, Jesus came and stood among them and said, “Peace be with you!” ²⁰ After he said this, he showed them his hands and side. The disciples were overjoyed when they saw the Lord. ²¹ Again Jesus said, “Peace be with you! As the Father has sent me, I am sending you.” ²² And with that he breathed on them and said, “Receive the Holy Spirit. ²³ If you forgive anyone’s sins, their sins are forgiven; if you do not forgive them, they are not forgiven.”

²⁴ Now Thomas (also known as Didymus), one of the Twelve, was not with the disciples when Jesus came. ²⁵ So the other disciples told him, “We have seen the Lord!” But he said to them, “Unless I see the nail marks in his hands and put my finger where the nails were, and put my hand into his side, I will not believe.” ²⁶ A week later his disciples were in the house again, and Thomas was with them. Though the doors were locked, Jesus came and stood among them and said, “Peace be with you!” ²⁷ Then he said to Thomas, “Put your finger here; see my hands. Reach out your hand and put it into my side. Stop doubting and believe.”

²⁸ Thomas said to him, “My Lord and my God!” ²⁹ Then Jesus told him, “Because you have seen me, you have believed; blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.”

REFLECT

Where has disappointment calloused into doubt? What would it take to bring it to Jesus honestly, instead of carrying it alone?

PRAYER

Jesus, meet me with peace, not correction. Let your wounds become the doorway to whatever I have stopped believing could be healed.

04

THE SHORE

*Can failure be the very place love comes
looking for you?*

PETER • JOHN 21:1-19

The charcoal fire.

John's gospel seems to end after the Thomas story. Then, as if one more thing needed saying, he adds a final chapter—centered on Peter.

We do not hear much about what Peter has been doing since the tomb. But we remember where we last saw him clearly: at his lowest moment.

Jesus was on trial in the dark. Peter had vowed he would never abandon him—that he would die before denying him. But when the pressure came, he could not hold it together. He lingered at the edges of the trial, warming himself at a charcoal fire, and when a servant girl identified him as one of Jesus' followers, he denied it three times. Then, across the courtyard, Jesus turned and looked straight at him. The rooster crowed. It was the worst moment of Peter's life, and the smell of that fire never left him.

Now, in John 21, we find him back on the Sea of Galilee. Back to fishing. Back to his old name—Simon, not Peter, "the Rock." He must have felt like anything but a foundation.

Some of us know this place. Failure. Promises made and broken. The habit we fell back into. The thing we swore we would never do again—and did.

Then a familiar scene unfolds. A man on the shore tells them to cast their nets on the other side of the boat—the same words spoken the day Jesus first called Peter, Andrew, James, and John away from these waters. And it happens again: nets breaking with fish. Peter's memory floods back. "It is the Lord!" He does not wait for the boat. He swims.

When they landed, they saw a fire of burning coals there, with fish and bread on it.

There are only two places in John's gospel where this exact phrase appears—a fire of burning coals. Once, at the moment of Peter's greatest failure. Now, here, at this moment. Jesus meets him again, by the same kind of fire.

Some smells pull you back to a place instantly. Jesus sets this scene on purpose—a meal that echoes the day they first met, and carries the scent of the night Peter failed him most.

Do you love me?

Jesus asks Peter three questions. One for every denial.

“Do you love me?” Jesus uses the word *agape*—love without condition, the strongest word available.

“Lord, you know I love you,” Peter answers—but he uses *phileo*, brotherly affection. He cannot bring himself to claim more than that. The smell of his failure is still in the air.

There is an honesty in that worth noticing. The bravado is gone—“I will die before I deny you” has met reality. What is left is simpler: Jesus, this is all I’ve got.

And Jesus says: that will be enough.

For his three denials, Peter receives not three corrections, but three commissionings.

“Feed my lambs.” “Take care of my sheep.” “Feed my sheep.”

| *And finally: “Follow me!”*

In other words: I called you away from these boats once before. I renamed you—not for who you were, but for who I would make you. I knew you would fail. I told you that you would. And I have forgiven you, and I am still calling you.

So get up. Come, follow me.

SCRIPTURE • JOHN 21:1-19 (NIV)

¹ Afterward Jesus appeared again to his disciples, by the Sea of Galilee. It happened this way: ² Simon Peter, Thomas (also known as Didymus), Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples were together. ³ “I’m going out to fish,” Simon Peter told them, and they said, “We’ll go with you.” So they went out and got into the boat, but that night they caught nothing. ⁴ Early in the morning, Jesus stood on the shore, but the disciples did not realize that it was Jesus. ⁵ He called out to them, “Friends, haven’t you any fish?” “No,” they answered. ⁶ He said, “Throw your net on the right side of the boat and you will find some.” When they did, they were unable to haul the net in because of the large number of fish. ⁷ Then the disciple whom Jesus loved said to Peter, “It is the Lord!” As soon as Simon Peter heard him say, “It is the Lord,” he wrapped his outer garment around him (for he had taken it off) and jumped into the water. ⁸ The other disciples followed in the boat, towing the net full of fish, for they were not far from shore, about a hundred yards. ⁹ When they landed, they saw a fire of burning coals there with fish on it, and some bread. ¹⁰ Jesus said to them, “Bring some of the fish you have just caught.” ¹¹ So Simon Peter climbed back into the boat and dragged the net ashore. It was full of large fish, 153, but even with so many the net was not torn. ¹² Jesus said to them, “Come and have breakfast.” None of the disciples dared ask him, “Who are you?” They knew it was the Lord. ¹³ Jesus came, took the bread and gave it to them, and did the same with the fish. ¹⁴ This was now the third time Jesus appeared to his disciples after he was raised from the dead. ¹⁵ When they had finished eating, Jesus said to Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” he said, “you know that I love you.” Jesus said, “Feed my lambs.” ¹⁶ Again Jesus said, “Simon son of John, do you love me?” He answered, “Yes, Lord, you know that I love you.” Jesus said, “Take care of my sheep.” ¹⁷ The third time he said to him, “Simon son of John, do you love me?” Peter was hurt because Jesus asked him the third time, “Do you love me?” He said, “Lord, you know all things; you know that I love you.” Jesus said, “Feed my sheep. ¹⁸ Very truly I tell you, when you were younger you dressed yourself and went where you wanted; but when you are old you will stretch out your hands, and someone else will dress you and lead you where you do not want to go.” ¹⁹ Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God. Then he said to him, “Follow me!”

REFLECT

Where do you need to hear “follow me” again—not despite the failure, but after it?

PRAYER

Jesus, call me again. I do not have more than “this is all I’ve got”—meet me there, the way you met Peter.

Firstfruits

For Mary, grief became holy ground. For Thomas, doubt became holy ground. For Peter, failure became holy ground.

Jesus did not just heal them. He did not just forgive them. He restored them—and then called them into his kingdom.

Mary became known as the Apostle to the Apostles. Many historians believe she shaped the Gospel accounts with her own memory of these events. In time, she became something like a picture of the church itself—discarded, then seen; demonized, then loved; thrown away, then called.

Thomas carried the good news as far as India. To this day, there are Christians there whose last name is Thomas, tracing their spiritual lineage to the man who once said he would not believe without proof.

Peter became the Rock—never perfect, spending the rest of his life doing exactly what Jesus asked: caring for the church. When his final test came, he did not run. He was crucified for his faith, and asked to be hung upside down, convinced he did not deserve the same death as his Lord.

The resurrection does not erase grief, doubt, or failure. It gives them a future.

The world was already upside down—grief, doubt, failure, an empire arguing over what was even true. Jesus did not wait for it to calm down. He entered it, in a garden, and started turning it right side up. Starting with a woman who thought he was a gardener. A man who needed to touch a wound. A fisherman who could not look him in the eye.

This is what the resurrection means: what happened to Jesus is what will happen to everything broken. First him. Then his people. Then, one day, the whole earth.

Follow Me

This Easter, you are invited into this story—not as a spectator, but as someone Jesus is looking for, the same way he found Mary in a garden, Thomas in a locked room, Peter at a fire on the shore.

So: will you follow him? Will you let him turn your world right side up?

BLESSING

Whatever holy ground grief, doubt, or failure has marked in you—may you meet him there.

May your name be spoken. May your wounds find their doorway. May you hear, again, “follow me.”

And may the hope that is living, because he is living, hold you.

THE KINGDOM DOES NOT TURN THE WORLD UPSIDE DOWN.

IT TURNS AN UPSIDE-DOWN WORLD RIGHT SIDE UP.

Living Hope — Meeting the Risen Jesus

THE SERMON

This study is drawn from the message “In Jesus” (Easter), preached at Willamette Christian Church. Listen or watch: willamette.cc/messages/in-jesus/easter

SCRIPTURE

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ABOUT THIS STUDY

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